graphics/Logo-schwarz.pdf

Design Games

[Draft: No ‘naustrian’ text for polylingual ‘Subtitle’.]

BACHELORARBEIT

zur Erlangung des akademischen Grades

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Software Engineering

eingereicht von

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Betreuung: Pretitle Hilda Tellioğlu, Posttitle

Wien, 30. September 2026

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graphics/Logo-schwarz.pdf

Design Games

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BACHELOR’S THESIS

submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of

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in

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by

Sami Pasquali
Registration Number 11809912

to the Faculty of Informatics

at the TU Wien

Advisor: Pretitle Hilda Tellioğlu, Posttitle

Vienna, September 30, 2026

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Sami Pasquali

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Wien, 30. September 2026

Sami Pasquali

Danksagung

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Acknowledgements

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Kurzfassung

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Abstract

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CHAPTER 1

Design Games

[Braa] describes Design games as a way of organizing participation in design projects. [TPT] notes that they (Design Games) provide a starting point for facilitating user participation and contribution.

1.1 History

1.2 Connection to Games

1.3 Categories and Classification of Design Games

1.4 Mechanics of Design Games

Throughout the literature review a number of reoccuring mechanics have been identified. The mechanics are subsequently clustered in 4 Clusters of effects they have on co-design sessions, when design games are used. Many mechanics can be attributed to multiple effects and are therefore included in more than one cluster.

1.4.1 Break existing habits

Breaking existing habits is a shift from everday logical thinking to generative, imaginative and lateral thinking. It grounds abstract thinking into a concrete reality so participants aren't overwhelmed by a blank canvas and overcomes potential power relations participants are part of usually.

Chance

Element of chance stems from the surrealist movement. "Games are often based on a wish to get out of habits, experience new and be taken by surprise" [Brab]. This might

come in the form of a dice, used to decide which topic or question to work on next.

Combining elements that do not fit together

People can be triggered out of their normal thinking patterns by, sometimes unusual, associations, suggestions or actions writen on a card [RW]

Facilitation

A facilitator can leave out elements to increase the focus more on a specific topic or influence which topic or question is to be worked on next [KKM]

Element of fun & Ludic drive

The essence of play lies in the intensity and absorption of players. It is referred to as the "Fun element". This absorption has to be based on voluntary participation and acceptance of the game rules [BMB].

Presupplied Input

How topics are framed by the supplied game material matters to the outcome of the game [BMB].

Involving stakeholders

Participants should come from different backgrounds and explore cooperation through playing. Design Games establish out-of-the-ordinary communication that breaks existing routines and communication habits, allowing new problem solving approaches to emerge [FGKM]

Magic circle

The magic circle is a temporary sphere of activity in which the laws of ordinary life do not count. It invites participants to think beyond the ordinary and envision alternative solutions [VM]. [FGKM]

Game rules

When playing, participants impersonate new roles that are defined by rules. Rules define what goal players strive to achieve, how success is defined and what actions are allowed. Thus, rules establish creative freedom by excluding ordinary life, while simultaneously forming its boundaries [FGKM].

A defined winning condition and rules to guide argumentation are found to make it easier for participants to reach consensus, which is described as more troublesome in classic co-design workshops with strangers [ZPZ$^+$].

Tangible game materials

Through Concept Design Games it has been found that Game Pieces and Game Boards can be abstracted to eliminate functional knowledge and former experiences participants bring with them [Braa]

1.4.2 Come up with creative ideas & Overcoming cognitive intertia

1.4.3 Create common understanding

1.4.4 Learn about concepts participants hold & Build empathy

1.4.5 Overcome power relations & Lower communication barriers in a group setting

1.4.6 Discussion

Analysieren warum bestimmte Mechaniken in fast jedem Paper auftauchen.

1.5 Benefits

1.6 Problems and Issues

CHAPTER 2

Examples of Design Game and their use in different domains

CHAPTER 3

Design Games in Design Thinking

3.1 Opportunities for Design Game use

Overview of Generative AI Tools Used

No AI tools were used for creating this paper.

Übersicht verwendeter Hilfsmittel

Keine

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